

# Maxwell Bloch Solver

User Guide

Version 8.5

Vahid Anari

[vahid.anari8@gmail.com](mailto:vahid.anari8@gmail.com)

This document describes the interactive desktop application for solving the Maxwell–Bloch equations, exploring driven coherent radiative regimes, and comparing model results with astronomical light curves.

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## 1 Overview

**Maxwell Bloch Solver** is a desktop GUI application for numerically solving the Maxwell–Bloch equations and visualizing the resulting intensity, inversion, pump, boundary-field, and relaxation-time profiles. The app is intended for coherent-radiation problems in which a driven resonant medium is modeled with a one-dimensional Maxwell–Bloch system.

In astrophysical work, the same framework can be used to study several regimes, including:

- steady or slowly varying **maser** amplification,
- transient **superradiant** bursts,
- weakly radiative or suppressed-response regimes that may be interpreted as **subradiant** behaviour depending on the chosen initial conditions and relaxation times.

The application provides:

- interactive parameter editing with sliders, line edits, and combo boxes,
- automatic re-solving when physical solver parameters change,
- two operating modes: **standalone simulation** and **fit mode**,
- overlay of simulation results with observational light curves,
- JSON-based parameter/configuration saving,
- export of the current figure to PDF, PNG, or SVG,
- a PDF export report containing metadata and the current parameter state.

### Note

The app is designed around fast interactive exploration. In normal use, there is no separate “Run” button: changing a solver parameter triggers a new solve automatically.

## 2 Physical Model

The solver evolves a dimensionless one-dimensional Maxwell–Bloch system for a driven two-level medium. The equations solved by the application are

$$\frac{\partial w}{\partial \tau'} = A' R - \frac{w - w_0}{T_1'} + \Lambda_n', \quad (1)$$

$$\frac{\partial R}{\partial \tau'} = -A' w - \frac{R - R_0}{T_2'}, \quad (2)$$

$$\frac{\partial A'}{\partial z'} = -\eta R, \quad (3)$$

where  $w$  is the population inversion,  $R$  is the medium coherence, and  $A'$  is the dimensionless field envelope. The solver works in normalised variables, with  $\tau' = \tau/T_0$  and  $z' = z/L$  a propagation coordinate normalised to the sample length  $L$ .

| Symbol                      | Meaning                                                                |
|-----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| $w(\tau', z')$              | Population inversion $\rho_{22} - \rho_{11}$                           |
| $R(\tau', z')$              | Coherence envelope ( $\rho_{21} = \frac{1}{2}R e^{i(kz - \omega t)}$ ) |
| $A'(\tau', z')$             | Dimensionless field envelope                                           |
| $\tau' = \tau/T_0$          | Normalised retarded time                                               |
| $z' = z/L$                  | Normalised propagation distance                                        |
| $T'_1 = T_1/T_0$            | Longitudinal relaxation time (may vary with $\tau'$ )                  |
| $T'_2 = T_2/T_0$            | Transverse dephasing time (may vary with $\tau'$ )                     |
| $\eta = T_0/T_R$            | Dimensionless coupling parameter                                       |
| $\Lambda'_n = T_0\Lambda_n$ | Dimensionless pump rate                                                |
| $w_0, R_0$                  | Equilibrium inversion and coherence                                    |

The physical reference time  $T_0$  is set in the **Sample** tab. By default,  $T_0 = 86400$  s (one day), but any positive value may be used. The derivation of these equations from first principles is given in the companion Equations Reference document.

## 2.1 Numerical Method

The application solves the system numerically on a time-space grid. The matter variables are advanced in time with a fourth-order Runge-Kutta scheme, while the field is propagated through the spatial grid. Performance-critical loops are accelerated with Numba.

## 2.2 Input Profiles

The boundary field, the pump, and the relaxation times are entered as time profiles. Two profile types are used.

### *Pulse profiles (boundary field and pump)*

The boundary field  $A'|_{z'=0}$  and each pump contribution are sums of  $N$   $\text{sech}^2$  pulses,

$$f(\tau') = \sum_{i=0}^{N-1} a^i \text{sech}^2\left(\frac{\tau' - \tau_0^i}{w^i}\right), \quad (4)$$

with amplitude  $a^i$ , center  $\tau_0^i$ , and width  $w^i$ .

### *Step profiles (relaxation times)*

Each of  $T'_1$  and  $T'_2$  is either a constant or a sequence of smoothed steps between  $N$  levels  $y^0, \dots, y^{N-1}$ ,

$$y(\tau') = y^0 + \sum_{i=1}^{N-1} \frac{y^i - y^{i-1}}{2} \left[ 1 + \tanh\left(\frac{\tau' - \tau_0^i}{w^i}\right) \right]. \quad (5)$$

Step  $i$  switches from  $y^{i-1}$  to  $y^i$  around  $\tau_0^i$ , over a time of order  $2w^i$ . With  $N = 1$  the profile is the constant  $y^0$ .

### Common options

In asymmetric mode, both profile types use separate widths on each side of the center,

$$w^i = \begin{cases} w_l^i, & \tau' < \tau_0^i, \\ w_r^i, & \tau' > \tau_0^i. \end{cases} \quad (6)$$

An optional spacing control places the centers at regular intervals of  $\tau_p$ :

$$\tau_0^i = \tau_0^0 + i \tau_p \quad (\text{pulses}), \quad \tau_0^i = \tau_0^1 + (i - 1) \tau_p \quad (\text{steps}). \quad (7)$$

This is useful for repeated pulses or regularly spaced changes.

## 3 Getting Started

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### 3.1 Launching the Application

From the project root directory, run

```
python main.py
```

A splash screen appears during startup, followed by the main window.

### 3.2 Operating Modes

The application has two main modes.

1. **Standalone simulation mode:** used when no data folder is loaded. The app solves the Maxwell–Bloch system directly from the current parameters.
2. **Fit mode:** entered after loading a light-curve folder. In this mode, the top panel overlays observational data and the model curve for one selected velocity component.

### 3.3 Main Window Layout

The main window is divided into three user-facing areas.

- **Top toolbar (fit mode only):** velocity navigation, save/unsave controls, an “Only saved velocities” filter, and a  $\chi^2$ -style mismatch readout.
- **Central plot area:** two vertically stacked panels that share the time axis. The top panel shows intensity or flux; the bottom panel shows one selected auxiliary curve.
- **Parameter tabs:** organized controls for the sample, solver grid, initial conditions, driving terms, fit alignment, and display ranges.

A small selector labeled **Bottom Plot** appears beside the velocity controls and chooses which auxiliary quantity is shown in the lower panel.

## 4 Parameter Tabs

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### 4.1 Sample Tab

The **Sample** tab defines the global physical scaling:

| Parameter                 | Symbol   | Description                   |
|---------------------------|----------|-------------------------------|
| Transition frequency      | $\nu$    | Line frequency                |
| Spontaneous emission rate | $\Gamma$ | Einstein- <i>A</i> -type rate |
| Time scale                | $T_0$    | Physical reference time       |
| Sample length             | $L$      | Physical propagation length   |
| Number density            | $n_0$    | Medium number density         |

From these values, the app derives internal scaling quantities such as the coupling constant  $\eta$ . The expression used by the app can be viewed from **Info**  $\rightarrow$  **Scaling Formula**.

## 4.2 Grid Tab

The **Grid** tab controls the numerical resolution:

| Parameter       | Symbol     | Description                           |
|-----------------|------------|---------------------------------------|
| Time points     | $N_t$      | Number of time-grid samples           |
| Spatial points  | $N_z$      | Number of propagation steps           |
| Total time span | $T_{\max}$ | Simulation duration in units of $T_0$ |

Increasing  $N_t$  or  $N_z$  generally improves resolution but also increases solve time.

## 4.3 Slice Tab

The **Slice** tab selects which spatial position is shown in the plots. The displayed solution is taken from one sampled  $z$  plane within the interval  $[0, 1]$ . Changing only the selected slice updates the displayed curve immediately. If the underlying slice array length is changed, the app performs a new solve.

## 4.4 $T_1$ and $T_2$ Tabs

The  **$T_1$**  and  **$T_2$**  tabs set the longitudinal relaxation time  $T_1$  and the transverse dephasing time  $T_2$ , in units of  $T_0$ . Each uses a step-profile editor (Section 2.2):

- $N = 1$ : the relaxation time is a single constant value,
- $N > 1$ : the relaxation time changes between  $N$  levels through smoothed steps, each with its own center  $\tau_0^i$  and width  $w^i$  (or  $w_l^i$  and  $w_r^i$  in asymmetric mode).

With  $N = 1$  only the level slider is shown; the step controls appear when  $N$  is increased. Index  $i = 0$  is the initial level and has no step, so its center and width controls are disabled.

## 4.5 ICs Tab

The **ICs** tab defines the initial state of the medium. Two input styles are available:

- **$\theta_0$  mode:** the initial state is set through a Bloch-angle parameter.
- **Direct mode:** the initial inversion and coherence are entered directly as  $w|_{\tau=0}$  and  $R|_{\tau=0}$ .

This tab is especially important when exploring the transition between weak response, maser-like response, and superradiant burst behaviour.

## 4.6 BCs Tab

The **BCs** tab defines the boundary field  $A|_{z=0}(\tau)$  as a sum of  $\text{sech}^2$  pulses (Section 2.2). Unlike a single-pulse editor, this widget supports a **multi-component** profile:

- $N$ : number of components,
- $i$ : currently edited component index,
- component amplitude  $A^i$ ,
- center  $\tau_0^i$ ,
- either a symmetric width  $w^i$  or asymmetric widths  $w_l^i$  and  $w_r^i$ ,
- optional regular spacing via  $\tau_p$ .

Additional checkboxes allow the user to force all components to share the same amplitude and/or widths. The **Show values** button opens a table of all component values.

## 4.7 Pump 1, Pump 2, and Pump 3 Tabs

The **Pump 1**, **Pump 2**, and **Pump 3** tabs define three independent contributions to the total pump,

$$\Lambda_n(\tau) = \Lambda_n^{(1)}(\tau) + \Lambda_n^{(2)}(\tau) + \Lambda_n^{(3)}(\tau). \quad (8)$$

Each tab uses the same pulse-profile editor as the **BCs** tab. This makes it easy to build single-pulse, repeated-pulse, or multi-episode pumping scenarios. A tab whose amplitudes are all zero contributes nothing.

## 4.8 Fit Mode Tab

The **Fit Mode** tab is enabled only when a data folder is loaded. It does not change the physical solve itself. Instead, it controls the conversion, alignment, and scaling used when the model is displayed against data.

| Control             | Description                                                             |
|---------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Data time unit      | Time unit used for the imported data axis (d, h, m, s, ms, $\mu$ s, ns) |
| Data flux unit      | Flux unit for the imported data (currently Jy)                          |
| Data time offset    | Constant shift applied to the loaded data times                         |
| Results time offset | Horizontal shift applied to the model curve                             |
| Intensity scale     | Vertical scale applied to the displayed model intensity                 |

### Note

In fit mode, the displayed model curve is rescaled for plotting. The time axis is converted using the chosen data unit, and the intensity is peak-normalized internally before the user-selected display scale is applied.

## 4.9 Range Tab

The **Range** tab controls the visible axis limits for:

- time,
- top-panel flux/intensity,
- $w$ ,
- $\Lambda_n$ ,



- $A|_{z=0}$ .
- $T_1$ ,
- $T_2$ .

Each quantity uses a two-handle range slider.

## 5 The Plot Area

### 5.1 Top Panel

The top panel shows:

- **standalone mode:** model intensity  $I(t)$ ,
- **fit mode:** observational flux points together with the transformed model curve.

In fit mode, the plotted data points come from the loaded light-curve file for the currently selected velocity.

### 5.2 Bottom Panel

The bottom panel displays one auxiliary quantity chosen from the **Bottom Plot** selector:

| Option      | Displayed quantity                             |
|-------------|------------------------------------------------|
| $w$         | Population inversion at the selected $z$ slice |
| $\Lambda_n$ | Total pump profile                             |
| $A _{z=0}$  | Boundary field $A _{z=0}$                      |
| $T_1$       | Longitudinal relaxation time $T_1(\tau)$       |
| $T_2$       | Transverse dephasing time $T_2(\tau)$          |

### 5.3 Current Span Marker

When a BC, pump,  $T_1$ , or  $T_2$  tab is active, the app can highlight the currently selected component: a vertical line marks its center  $\tau_0^i$  and a shaded region indicates its width. For pulse profiles this is the selected pulse; for step profiles it is the selected step.

The marker is shown only when it matches the quantity in the bottom panel:

- BC marker with bottom plot  $A|_{z=0}$ ,
- pump marker with bottom plot  $\Lambda_n$ ,
- $T_1$  marker with bottom plot  $T_1$ ,
- $T_2$  marker with bottom plot  $T_2$ .

No marker is shown when  $T_1$  or  $T_2$  is a constant ( $N = 1$ ).

## 6 Fit Mode

Fit mode is used to compare the model with observed light curves one velocity component at a time.

## 6.1 Loading a Data Folder

To enter fit mode:

1. choose **File** → **Open Data Folder...** (Ctrl+Shift+O),
2. select the folder containing the data files,
3. if more than one period group is present, choose the desired period,
4. review the import summary dialog.

If matching saved parameters already exist in the folder, they are loaded automatically.

### *Expected File Naming*

The application expects filenames of the form

SourceName\_v=12.3.txt

SourceName\_p1\_v=12.3.txt

where the optional token p1, p2, ... is a period label and v= denotes the velocity.

### *Folder Rules*

A valid data folder should satisfy the following conditions:

- all valid files belong to the same source,
- files are either all period-tagged or all non-period-tagged,
- each light-curve file is plain text,
- the app reads the **first two numeric columns** as time and flux,
- blank lines and lines beginning with # are ignored.

### **Important**

**File** → **Open Parameters...** is intended for standalone parameter snapshots, not for fit-mode source files. Fit-mode parameter sets are loaded automatically from the selected data folder.

## 6.2 Velocity Navigation

Once a data folder is open, the velocity toolbar becomes active. You can:

- move to the previous or next component,
- choose a component directly from the drop-down list,
- filter the list with **Only saved velocities**,
- save or unsave the current component.

Each velocity component has its own stored parameter state.

## 6.3 Save and Unsave Behaviour

In fit mode, pressing **Save** or using **Ctrl+S** saves the current velocity's parameters into a single source-level JSON file in the loaded folder:

SourceName\_params.json

SourceName\_p1\_params.json

The file stores the saved states for all velocities in the selected source/period group.

The **Unsave** button removes the saved state of the current velocity from that file.

If a velocity has unsaved changes and you try to switch away from it, the app asks whether you want to save, discard, or cancel the change.

## 6.4 Mismatch Readout

The toolbar shows a quantity labeled  $\chi^2$ . Within the app, this is a **reduced  $\chi^2$ -like mismatch** computed over the currently visible data range. It is useful as a quick comparison metric, but it is **not** a formal statistical reduced chi-square based on measurement uncertainties.

## 6.5 Closing Data

Choose **File** → **Close Data** (Ctrl+W) to leave fit mode and return to the default standalone state. If there are unsaved changes, the app prompts before closing the folder.

## 7 File Menu Reference

The shortcuts below use Windows/Linux conventions. On macOS, replace **Ctrl** with **Cmd** and **Alt** with **Option**.

| Menu Item                  | Shortcut            | Description                                       |
|----------------------------|---------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Open Data Folder...        | <b>Ctrl+Shift+O</b> | Import a data folder and enter fit mode           |
| Recent Data Folders        | —                   | Reopen a recently used source folder              |
| Open Current Source Folder | <b>Ctrl+O</b>       | Open the active source folder in the file browser |
| Open Parameters...         | <b>Ctrl+Shift+P</b> | Import a standalone parameter snapshot            |
| Close Data                 | <b>Ctrl+W</b>       | Close the loaded data folder                      |
| Save Parameters            | <b>Ctrl+S</b>       | Save current parameters                           |
| Save Parameters As...      | <b>Ctrl+Shift+S</b> | Save a standalone snapshot to a new file          |
| Save Parameters as Default | <b>Ctrl+Alt+S</b>   | Store the current state as the startup default    |
| Export Plot...             | <b>Ctrl+E</b>       | Export the current figure                         |
| Quit                       | <b>Ctrl+Q</b>       | Exit the application                              |

### Note

In fit mode, **Save Parameters As...** is disabled. The active save target is the source-level parameter file inside the loaded data folder.

## 8 View Menu Reference

| Menu Item                         | Shortcut          | Description                                           |
|-----------------------------------|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| Time Grid → Major / Minor         | —                 | Toggle major and minor time-axis grid lines           |
| Flux Grid → Major / Minor         | —                 | Toggle major and minor grid lines on the top panel    |
| Bottom Panel Grid → Major / Minor | —                 | Toggle major and minor grid lines on the bottom panel |
| Show Slider Range                 | <b>Ctrl+Alt+R</b> | Show or hide slider range labels                      |
| Line Colors                       | —                 | Change the colors of plotted curves                   |

Line-color choices and several view preferences are persisted between sessions.

## 9 Info and Help Menus

| Menu Item           | Shortcut          | Description                                    |
|---------------------|-------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Data Summary        | <b>Ctrl+Alt+D</b> | Show source, period, velocity, and data ranges |
| Scaling Formula     | <b>Ctrl+Alt+F</b> | Show the scaling expression used by the app    |
| Equations Reference | <b>Ctrl+Alt+E</b> | Open the bundled equations reference PDF       |
| Solver Step Viewer  | <b>Ctrl+Alt+V</b> | Open the interactive solver-step viewer        |
| User Guide          | <b>F1</b>         | Open the user guide PDF if available           |
| About This App      | —                 | Show application and author information        |
| About Qt            | —                 | Show the Qt about dialog                       |

## 10 Exporting Plots

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Use **File** → **Export Plot...** to save the current figure.

- **PDF**: exports the current plot on the first page and appends one or more text-report pages containing metadata and the current parameter values.
- **PNG** / **SVG**: exports the figure only.

The exported PDF also includes document metadata such as title, creator, and author name.

## 11 Saving and Loading Parameters

---

### 11.1 Saved JSON Structure

Saved parameter snapshots use the structure

```
{
  "metadata": { ... },
  "config":   { ... },
  "params":   { ... }
}
```

where:

- **metadata** stores version, save time, username, and mode information,
- **config** stores widget/configuration state,
- **params** stores the current parameter values.

In fit mode, the **params** section stores the saved values for all saved velocities in the source/period group.

### 11.2 App Defaults

The command **File** → **Save Parameters as Default** stores the current standalone state in the platform's persistent application settings using Qt's **QSettings**. On later launches, the app restores these saved defaults instead of the factory defaults.

## 12 Typical Workflows

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### 12.1 Standalone Simulation Workflow

1. Launch the application.
2. Set the physical sample parameters in **Sample**.
3. Adjust the numerical resolution in **Grid** if needed.
4. Choose the initial state in **ICs**.
5. Set the relaxation times in **T<sub>1</sub>** and **T<sub>2</sub>**, either as constants or as step profiles.
6. Define the boundary field in **BCs**.
7. Add up to three pump contributions in **Pump 1**, **Pump 2**, and **Pump 3**.

8. Inspect different propagation slices in **Slice**.
9. Use **Range** to zoom the displayed region.
10. Export the plot or save the parameters when satisfied.

## 12.2 Observational Fitting Workflow

1. Open a data folder with **File** → **Open Data Folder**....
2. Select a velocity component from the toolbar.
3. Use **Fit Mode** to choose the correct data time unit and apply any needed offsets.
4. Adjust the physical and driving parameters in **Sample**, **T<sub>1</sub>**, **T<sub>2</sub>**, **ICs**, **BCs**, and the pump tabs.
5. Use the fit controls to align the model in time and scale it vertically.
6. Monitor the  $\chi^2$ -style mismatch as a quick diagnostic.
7. Save the current velocity.
8. Repeat for the remaining velocities.

## 13 Troubleshooting

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### The plot does not seem to change after I edit a value.

Solver parameters under `solve.*` trigger a new solve. Pure display parameters such as range settings, selected slice index, or fit offsets may update the display without re-solving.

### Open Parameters refuses one of my saved JSON files.

That file is probably a fit-mode source parameter file. Load the corresponding data folder instead; the app will read that file automatically.

### The imported folder is rejected.

Check the filename pattern and make sure the folder contains only one source name and is not mixing period-tagged and non-period-tagged data files.

### The solver becomes slow.

Large values of  $N_t$  and  $N_z$  increase compute time. The first solve after launch may also be slower because the JIT-compiled kernels are being prepared.

### The mismatch value is blank.

This happens when there is no loaded data, no visible overlap between the plotted data and model, or no valid interpolated comparison range.

### The PDF export contains extra pages.

This is expected. PDF export includes a report section with metadata and parameters in addition to the figure page.